# The seed of doubt

We live in a country where faith is stitched into the fabric of everyday life. A temple bell ringing in the morning, incense smoke drifting from a tiny home altar, a whispered prayer before boarding a train. These moments are so common that we rarely pause to question them. But somewhere between rituals and reality, between childhood stories and adult struggles, a silent storm brews in the mind of a thinker: *What is God, really? Is it belief? Is it fear? Or is it something we've just inherited, never questioned?*

This book began not with answers, but with questions. Deeply personal questions. Questions that kept me up at night, had me staring into the sky, and whispering quietly in moments of loneliness. Questions like: *Are we worshipping because we believe, or because we are told to? Why do people fight over whose God is true? And what if God doesn't look like anything we ever imagined?*

The intention here is not to insult faith, but to invite honesty. Not to disprove belief, but to understand it, from both the inside and the outside. This book is not written by a scholar sitting in an ivory tower, but by someone who grew up among the sacred, who wrestled with devotion, doubt, fear, science, and silence. In the pages ahead, you won't be told what to believe. You'll simply be asked to look at what you already believe and ask

yourself: Why?

Let's begin where all truth begins: with the personal struggle to make sense of the world we were born into.

## i. The Personal Struggle with Faith in India.

My struggle with faith began very early in life, not out of rebellion, but from genuine curiosity.

Growing up in India, I was surrounded by rituals, traditions, and spiritual practices. Almost everyone around me followed them with deep devotion, but few truly understood why they did what they did.

As a child, I would often ask my mother, "Why do we do this?" or "What will happen if we don't?" She would simply say, "It's our culture. If we don't follow it, God won't bless us." But this answer never satisfied me. I wasn't trying to be disrespectful; I was just searching for clarity. I wanted to know why God would withhold blessings simply because someone didn't follow a ritual.

I was born and raised in this kind of environment where belief was rarely questioned, and tradition was treated as truth. One particular memory stands out. I was walking with my friends when we saw a lemon placed in the middle of the road, covered with red powder. One of my friends whispered, "Don't step on it. That's black magic. If you step on it, something bad will happen to you."

Something inside me refused to believe that a lemon could have magical power. So, I challenged myself. I stepped on it. And… nothing happened. From that day on, I started questioning even more. Why do people follow rituals without understanding them? Does God really demand all this? Are we born just to

worship Him in specific ways? What kind of God would punish people for simply being curious or different? Between the ages of 10 and 15, I was a very practical thinker. I constantly asked questions not out of ego, but because I wanted to understand. Questions like:

"If we don't perform a certain prayer, will God really be angry?"

"What does God want from us?"

"What if there is no God at all?"

These questions often made me feel isolated, but I couldn't stop thinking. Another strange experience I remember was while watching movies. When I watched horror films, I would get scared feeling like someone was hiding behind me. I wouldn't even dare to turn around. But when I watched movies about God or divine stories, I felt completely safe. It was as if some invisible energy was protecting me. I wondered was that feeling real? Was it God's presence or just my own consciousness creating comfort?

When I turned 16, I joined college. That's when my thinking began to shift even more. I was introduced to subjects like physics, chemistry, and computer science, all grounded in logic and evidence. They made me think more deeply and practically. I wasn't just chasing marks or grades. I spent time reading the Bhagavad Gita, exploring topics like space, the universe, and philosophy. I wanted to understand existence from every angle.

During my undergraduate studies in Tumakuru, I was known as a calm, quiet, and thoughtful student. Sometimes, I was a little crazy too, but in a good way. I didn't compete with others academically. I focused more on learning and understanding life itself.

Near my hostel, there was a large statue of Lord Hanuman. I used to visit the temple every Saturday with great faith. But eventually, I asked myself: "Why only Saturday? Why not any other day?" When I questioned someone about this, they said, "You shouldn't question God. There's a reason behind everything."

But I noticed that people said this only when they didn't have the answer. They were repeating what they had heard from someone else just like a chain of beliefs passed down without inspection.

One night, I was walking outside in the dark and felt afraid. But the moment I saw the Hanuman statue, I suddenly felt safe, like a powerful energy was surrounding me. As I walked farther away and the statue disappeared from view, the fear returned. That made me think, was it God's protection I felt near the statue, or just my own belief giving me comfort?

I kept wondering:

Does God live in statues?

Why don't I feel protected in other places?

Is my mind creating these feelings, or is it something divine?

These thoughts never left me.

Over the years, I visited many spiritual places in India such as Ayodhya, Varanasi, Vrindavan, Mathura, Puri Jagannath, and more. In those holy places, surrounded by chants, devotion, and tradition, I often felt a strong presence as if God truly existed. The energy was powerful and emotional. But once I left those temples and returned to the outside world, I saw another side of reality. People sacrificing animals in the name of God. Crimes, corruption, and rape cases rising. Pollution destroying our environment. The poor struggling daily to survive. The rich becoming richer by exploiting the system. People who committed terrible acts still worshipping in temples as if nothing had happened.

And I asked myself:

"If God exists, why does He allow all this?"

"Why doesn't He stop injustice?"

"Why do good people suffer and bad people rise?"

"Is this really part of a divine plan?"

These questions made my belief more complex. I wasn't turning away from God; I was trying to understand Him. Or maybe… I was trying to understand myself.

My struggle with faith did not turn me into a non-believer. It turned me into a better human being someone who values honesty over blind belief, and understanding over rituals. That